Without moving the pick another inch, I relaxed my wrists, opened my hands, walked out from under the pick, and headed toward Jack.

The pick plunged to earth and stuck in the ground an inch or two from one of my bosses' toes. As Jack and I walked away together, he said: "That was the damnedest exhibition of laziness I've ever seen in my life."

When September arrived, our high school football conference established a new division for smaller players weighing up to 135 pounds and I was elected captain of the team, playing tackle and then guard.

I loved playing on the line: For me, it was probably a marriage made in heaven. It's as fundamental as anything in life—a collision between two bodies, one determined to advance, the other determined to resist; one man against another man, blocking, tackling, breaking through the line.

By my junior year, I had shot up to five feet, ten-and-a-half inches and weighed over 160 pounds. But although I made the varsity, by mid-season I was still warming the bench. Then one Saturday morning, the coach, who had decided he was unhappy with the playing of one of our first-string guards, convened our regular pre-game meeting in the locker room and, reading off the starting team, said—I'll never forget it—*"Right Guard, Reagan."*

Once I got in, I never let the other guy get his position back. The first string job was mine for the rest of the season and during my senior year, when I'd grown even bigger, I was a starter from the beginning.

About my second year in high school, I got one of the best jobs I ever had: I began the first of seven summers working as a lifeguard at Lowell Park, a three-hundred-acre forested sanctuary on the Rock River named for the poet James Russell Lowell, whose family had given the property to the city. I'd taken a course on lifesaving at the YMCA and when